Chapter 3

Emerging Ripples

The year of 1946 saw the playing out of different levels of political intrigue that contributed to a rapid churn of events which ultimately, in 1947, led to the break up of Maharaja Hari Singh's kingdom of Jammu and Kashmir. To begin with, the Prime Minister of the state, Ram Chandra Kak began to exploit the differences that arose between Sheikh Abdullah's National Conference and Mirwaiz Mohammad Yusuf Shah's Muslim Conference. Kak's deft political intrigue largely isolated the Muslim Conference from the Quit Kashmir movement. While Kak placed the state under martial law and arrested almost the entire top leadership of the National Conference and hundreds of its workers, he spared the Muslim Conference his wrath. Sheikh Abdullah, following an arrest and a three years' imprisonment sentence for sedition, escaped to Punjab, leaving the National Conference leaderless and in disarray. To outside observers like Pandit Nehru, it seemed that all popular support in the valley resided with Abdullah, since the Mirwaiz appeared to be out of touch with the popular political sentiment. Nehru, however, failed to read the fine print. Kak had also arrested Muslim Conference leader Chaudhry Ghulam Abbas, so that it would not appear that Abbas was in support of the Maharaja.[1] This deft action politically neutralised the Mirwaiz and facilitated Abbas's takeover of the Muslim Conference.